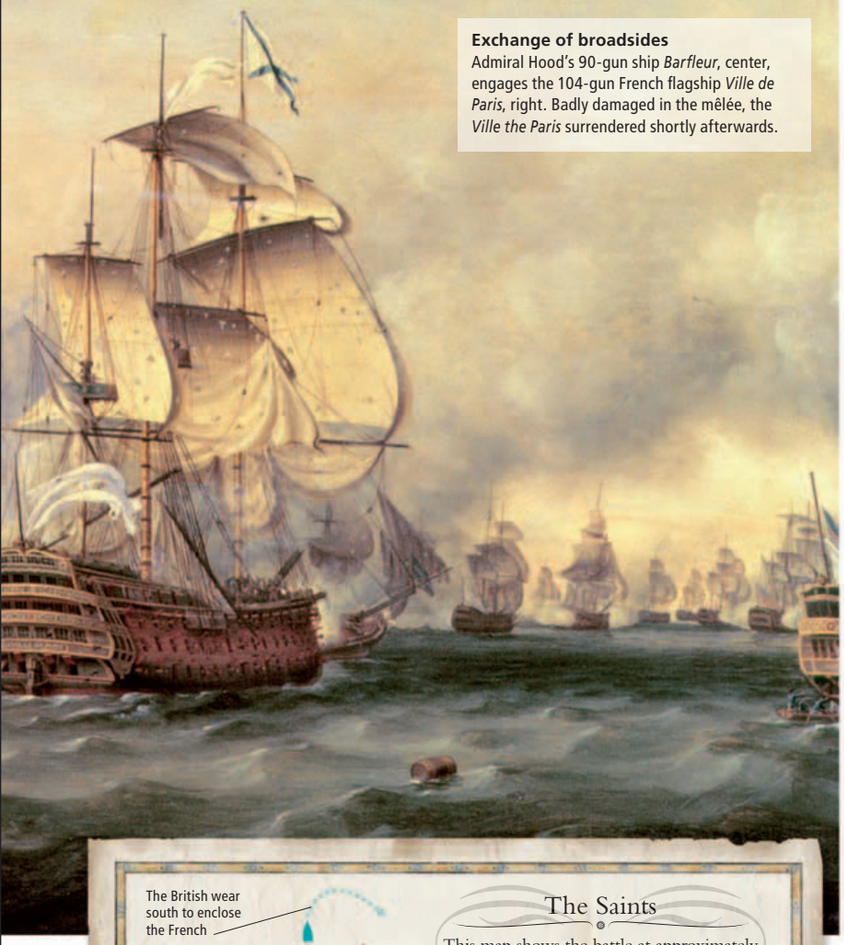
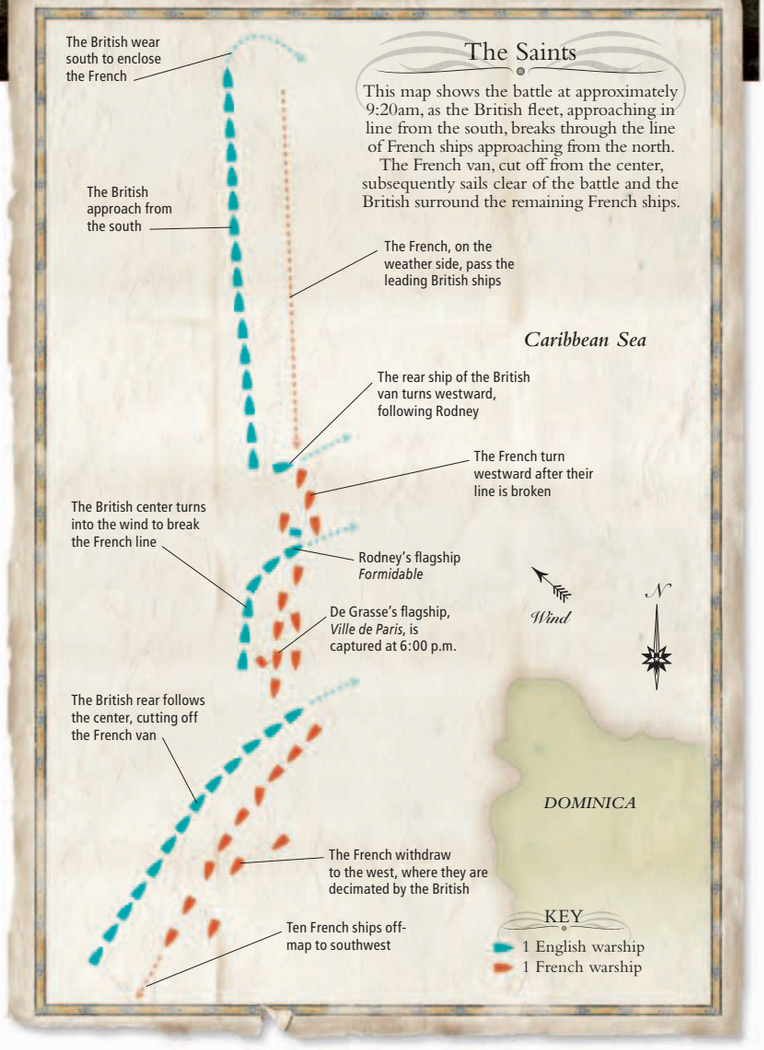


Exchange of broadsides
Admiral Hood's 90-gun ship *Barfleur*, center, engages the 104-gun French flagship *Ville de Paris*, right. Badly damaged in the mêlée, the *Ville the Paris* surrendered shortly afterwards.



AMERICAN REVOLUTIONARY WAR

PROVIDIEN



Date April 12, 1782
Forces French: 12 ships of the line; British: 11 ships of the line
Losses none

Location Off east coast of Sri Lanka

French admiral Pierre André de Suffren appeared off southeast India in February 1782 commanding a squadron of 12 ships. His mission was to contest the British takeover of French colonial outposts by cooperating with Indian Prince Hyder Ali. After an indecisive encounter with a British force under Vice Admiral Sir Edward Hughes at Sadras, Suffren sailed for Trincomalee in Ceylon (Sri Lanka), which he hoped to seize as a naval base. Vice Admiral Hughes intercepted him with 11 ships near the islet of Providien.

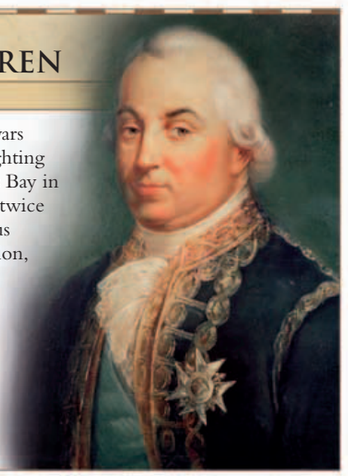
Suffren held the weather gage and pinned the British against a rocky coast. He closed with the British in line abreast, turning to line ahead to begin firing broadsides. But some of his captains, lacking stomach for a fight, hung back on the approach and only Suffren's flagship *Héros* and four other ships in the French center engaged at close range. In fierce fighting the British 64-gun *Monmouth* was disabled while *Héros* lost her foretopmast and the French 74-gun *Orient* caught fire. The onset of a violent rainstorm brought a general ceasefire as both sides strove to avoid running ashore or colliding in the crowded seas. The French ships withdrew the next day in serious need of repair, but after an improvised refit resumed operations.

1729–1788

PIERRE ANDRÉ DE SUFFREN

FRENCH ADMIRAL

Suffren de St Tropez took part in all France's wars against Britain from the 1740s to the 1780s, fighting at Toulon in 1744, Minorca in 1756, and Lagos Bay in 1759, as well as in many lesser actions. He was twice taken prisoner by the British. A fiery, impetuous character, he was critical of French naval tradition, believing lack of energy and initiative was responsible for repeated poor performances. Taking command in the Indian Ocean in 1782, he resolved to redeem his navy's honor with a display of fighting spirit. Although he won no outright victories, he kept his ships committed to combat under most difficult circumstances, earning the praise of friend and foe alike.



AMERICAN REVOLUTIONARY WAR

TRINCOMALEE



Date September 3, 1782
Forces French: 14 ships of the line; British: 12 ships of the line
Losses none

Location Off east coast of Sri Lanka

In August 1782 Suffren captured the port of Trincomalee from the British. Hughes sailed his squadron offshore, inviting the French to come out. Reinforced, Suffren now had clearly superior numbers, so he gave battle hoping for a crushing victory. As at Providien, many of Suffren's captains did not share his enthusiasm. Only Suffren's flagship *Héros*, along with *Ajax* and *Illustre*, initially engaged at closest range. In three hours' savage combat these ships suffered heavy losses. At one point *Héros'* flag was shot away, but Suffren bellowed: "Flags, flags, hoist them all around the ship." More French ships belatedly joined the fighting and the British suffered enough damage to feel the need to disengage, leaving the French in possession of Trincomalee.

AMERICAN REVOLUTIONARY WAR

CUDDALORE



Date June 20, 1783
Forces French: 15 ships of the line; British: 18 ships of the line
Losses none

Location Off Coromandel coast of India

In 1783 French army reinforcements arrived in India. The soldiers were soon trapped at Cuddalore, besieged by land and under naval blockade. Suffren sailed to contest the blockade, though his ships were in poor shape, undermanned, and outnumbered. He cleverly maneuvered to draw the British out of the Cuddalore roadstead and occupy it himself. Then, taking on board sepoys to help man his guns, he boldly went out to attack the superior British force. Both sides maintained a steady line through several hours' broadsides, ended by nightfall. The moral victory went to the French, still ready to take the offensive despite their patched sails and depleted crews. The news arrived shortly after that peace had already been declared.